ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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Sexual Health, Consent and Relationships: Decide With Information

Factual, judgement-free guidance on consent, protection and getting care

HEALTH & WELLBEING

Health & Wellbeing

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Freshers receive a lot of rumour and very little accurate information. This pack covers consent, contraception and barrier protection, common sexually transmitted infections, testing and where to get confidential care, with no moralising and no shame.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Define consent and describe the conditions that make it valid.
- Compare contraceptive methods and explain barrier protection.
- Recognise common STI symptoms and know that many infections are asymptomatic.
- Identify confidential sources of testing, treatment and support.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Consent and boundaries

Consent is an ongoing agreement, not a single moment.

- Consent must be freely given, informed, specific and reversible.
- A person can withdraw consent at any time, including during an act.
- Silence, coercion, pressure or intoxication do not constitute consent.
- Marriage or a previous relationship does not remove the need for consent.
- Agreeing to one act does not imply agreement to another.
- Respect a no immediately, and stop if you are unsure.

Support after assault
Seek medical attention quickly, preserve evidence where possible, and contact a trusted person or support service. What happened is not the survivor's fault.

Protection and contraception

Different methods do different jobs: contraception prevents pregnancy, while barrier protection reduces infection risk.

- Male condoms reduce the risk of pregnancy and most STIs when used correctly and consistently.
- Hormonal methods such as pills and injectables prevent pregnancy but do not protect against infection.
- Long-acting reversible methods are highly effective and require a provider.
- Emergency contraception reduces pregnancy risk after unprotected sex but is not routine contraception.
- Two methods used together give better protection than one alone.
- Consult a health provider before starting any method.

Infections, testing and care

Many STIs have no symptoms, so testing matters more than appearance.

- Common infections include HIV, gonorrhoea, chlamydia, syphilis, herpes and HPV.
- Symptoms can include discharge, sores, pain or burning on urination, but absence of symptoms is common.
- Testing is confidential and available at the university health centre and public facilities.
- Most bacterial STIs are curable with the right treatment; viral infections can be managed.
- Complete a full course of treatment and inform partners where appropriate.
- Never self-medicate with antibiotics from a chemist without testing.

Consent is a standard, not a mood

Consent is a clear, voluntary and informed agreement to a specific activity, given by someone with the capacity to give it. It can be withdrawn at any point, and it cannot be given in advance for an activity that has not been discussed. Silence is not consent; previous consent does not extend to a new occasion; being in a relationship does not create standing consent.

Alcohol and drugs complicate capacity. A person who is significantly intoxicated may not be able to give valid consent, and sex without valid consent is rape or sexual assault regardless of the relationship or the intentions of the other person.

Coercion includes pressure, guilt, threats, emotional manipulation and refusing to accept a no. Repeatedly asking until someone gives in is not persuasion; it is coercion. A healthy sexual relationship is one in which either person can say no without consequence.

Protection, testing and reproductive health

Condoms are the only method that protects against both pregnancy and sexually transmitted infections. Used correctly and consistently, they are highly effective; used inconsistently, they are not. Other contraceptive methods - pills, injectables, implants, intrauterine devices - are more effective for pregnancy prevention but do not protect against infection.

Common STIs, including chlamydia, gonorrhoea, syphilis and HIV, may be asymptomatic. Testing is therefore the only reliable way to know your status, and it is routine, confidential and available at the campus health centre. Free or subsidised testing and treatment exist; asking is normal.

Emergency contraception is most effective the sooner it is taken. If a condom fails or unprotected sex occurs, act within 72 hours and ask about post-exposure prophylaxis for HIV, which is time-critical.

> **The question to ask yourself**
> Would this person still be able to say no to me right now, comfortably? If the answer is unclear, stop and check.

Relationships, boundaries and getting help

Healthy relationships have four features: mutual respect, honesty, shared control over decisions, and the ability to disagree safely. Warning signs include monitoring messages, isolating a partner from friends, controlling money or clothing, explosive jealousy, and any physical violence. These escalate; they rarely improve on their own.

Setting boundaries is a skill: state what you need, be specific, and notice how the other person responds. A partner who responds to a boundary with anger or punishment is showing you something important.

If you experience sexual violence, it is not your fault. Seek medical attention promptly - within 72 hours where possible - for injury care, emergency contraception, STI prophylaxis and, if you choose, forensic evidence. Counselling, a trusted lecturer, the health centre and the police are all options, and the decision about reporting belongs to you.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Checking consent in a real situation

A partner has been drinking heavily and is initiating sex.

1. Assess capacity: is the person able to understand and communicate a decision right now?
2. If there is doubt, treat it as no.
3. Say what you are doing: "you have had a lot to drink, let us stop here".
4. Do not continue on the basis of earlier enthusiasm.
5. Check in the next day without pressure.
6. If the person is unwell, ensure they are safe and not left alone.

> **What to carry forward**
> Uncertainty is not a green light. Stop, and check when both people are clear.

2. Setting a boundary

A partner checks your phone and demands your location.

1. Name the behaviour specifically.
2. State the effect: it feels like surveillance and it is eroding trust.
3. State the boundary: you will not share passwords, and you will tell them where you are when it matters.
4. Observe the response: negotiation is fine, punishment is not.
5. Decide in advance what you will do if it continues.
6. Tell a trusted friend so the situation is not secret.

> **What to carry forward**
> Boundary plus observed response tells you more than any promise.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Define consent and explain why intoxication and coercion invalidate it.

15 marks

1. Consent: clear, voluntary, informed, specific, revocable.
2. Intoxication may remove capacity to decide.
3. Coercion removes voluntariness even if agreement is verbalised.
4. Silence and prior consent are not consent.

Q2. Compare contraceptive methods for pregnancy and infection protection.

10 marks

1. Condoms protect against both when used consistently.
2. Hormonal and long-acting methods are more effective for pregnancy but not for infection.
3. Dual protection combines both strategies.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Consent. A clear, voluntary, informed and specific agreement, revocable at any time.

Capacity. The ability to understand and communicate a decision.

Coercion. Pressure that removes the voluntariness of an agreement.

STI. A sexually transmitted infection, which may be asymptomatic.

Barrier method. A method such as a condom that physically prevents transmission.

Emergency contraception. A method used after unprotected sex, more effective the sooner it is taken.

PEP. Post-exposure prophylaxis, medication taken after possible HIV exposure.

Boundary. A stated limit on what a person will accept.

Reproductive health. Wellbeing in relation to reproduction and sexual function.

Confidentiality. The duty not to disclose health information without consent.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Understand

Consent.

- Write a definition in your own words.
- List three things that invalidate consent.
- Discuss one scenario with a trusted friend.

Week 2 - Protect

Methods.

- Learn how to use a condom correctly.
- List three contraceptive options and their limits.
- Know where to get emergency contraception.

Week 3 - Test

Status.

- Find the campus testing service.
- Know the window period.
- Get tested if you have been at risk.

Week 4 - Boundaries

Relationships.

- Write one boundary and how to state it.
- Identify two warning signs.
- Know the support contacts.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Your campus health centre's sexual health information.
- A guide on consent and healthy relationships for students.
- WHO guidance on contraception and STI prevention.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Define valid consent.

Answer: A freely given, informed, specific and reversible agreement, made without coercion and by someone with capacity.

2. Do hormonal contraceptives protect against STIs?

Answer: No. They prevent pregnancy but provide no protection against sexually transmitted infections.

3. Why can you not rely on symptoms to know your STI status?

Answer: Many infections are asymptomatic, so a person can be infected and transmit without any signs.

4. What should you do after unprotected sex where pregnancy is a concern?

Answer: Seek advice about emergency contraception as soon as possible, and get tested for STIs after the appropriate window.

5. Where can a student get confidential testing?

Answer: The university health centre or a public or private clinic; testing and treatment are meant to be confidential.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Learn the four elements of valid consent.
- [ ] Read about three contraceptive methods and their effectiveness.
- [ ] Locate the campus health centre and its opening hours.
- [ ] Know the window period for HIV and STI testing.
- [ ] Identify one trusted person to talk to about health concerns.
- [ ] Learn how to use a condom correctly.
- [ ] Find the contact details of a support service for assault survivors.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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